CASE STUDY

Reimagining BookMyShow:

Evaluating AI-Powered Hyperlocal Personalisation,
Pricing Transparency, and Community Discovery
for Sustainable Growth

Group 07

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PART A: CASE NARRATIVE

1. Introduction: The Protagonist and the Problem

Important Note on the Protagonist: Priya Sharma is a fictional character created for the purposes of this case study. While BookMyShow is a real company, no real senior executive by this name holds this role. The dilemma, however, is grounded entirely in real and verified data about the company, its competitors, and the Indian entertainment market.

It is mid-2026. Priya Sharma, a fictional Senior Vice-President of Product at Big Tree Entertainment Pvt. Ltd. — the parent company of BookMyShow — is preparing a critical strategy presentation for the company's board of directors. The question she must answer is: how does BookMyShow protect and grow its market leadership as a new, fast-moving competitor backed by Zomato's resources begins to challenge the platform's dominance?

On the surface, BookMyShow looks stronger than ever. In FY2025, the company reported total income of ₹1,869 crore and a net profit of ₹192 crore — up from ₹109 crore the previous year (Economic Times, 2025). Its live events business nearly doubled revenue to ₹756 crore in FY25, driven by high-profile events including Coldplay's India tour, for which BookMyShow was the official ticketing partner (ArdorComm Media, 2025). The platform holds approximately 78–80% of India's online movie ticketing market (GrowthX, 2024).

However, three warning signals are flashing at the same time. First, in November 2024, Zomato launched 'District' — a new lifestyle app that bundles dining, movie ticketing, concerts, and sports bookings in one place. Built after Zomato acquired Paytm Insider for ₹2,048 crore (Reuters, 2024), District won Google Play's Best App in India award for 2025 (Analytics Insight, 2025). It is now the platform's most credible challenger. Second, 67% of BookMyShow's own users cite hidden convenience fees as their biggest frustration (Primary Survey, 2024). Third, the platform's recommendation engine — last significantly updated in 2022 — is performing near the industry average, leaving high-value users feeling that the platform does not truly know their tastes.

Priya must formulate a strategic response across three possible directions: (A) rebuild the platform's AI engine to deliver truly personalised, hyperlocal event discovery; (B) be radically transparent about pricing to rebuild user trust; or (C) add a social-community layer that lets users discover events through friend networks and cultural communities. Each option has different costs, risks, timelines, and competitive implications. The board meeting is in two weeks.

2. Background of the Company

2.1 Founding and Growth

BookMyShow was founded in 1999 by Ashish Hemrajani, Parikshit Dar, and Rajesh Balpande in Mumbai, under the parent entity Big Tree Entertainment Pvt. Ltd. (Startuptalky, 2024). It started as a software reseller helping cinemas distribute tickets and nearly shut down during the Dot-Com crash of the early 2000s, surviving on minimal capital for several years.

The company's transformation came when India's digital infrastructure began to take off. BookMyShow launched its website in 2007 and its mobile app in 2012. As India's smartphone user base exploded — from 117 million in 2014 to over 600 million by 2022 (GSMA, 2023) — BookMyShow's early mobile-first bet paid off completely. Today, the platform operates in 650+ cities across India with 30 million+ monthly active users and 180 million+ tickets sold annually (Bernstein Research, 2024). In FY2025, total income reached ₹1,869 crore with a net profit of ₹192 crore (Economic Times, 2025). The company is valued at over $1.5 billion in pre-IPO estimates (BusinessModelCanvasTemplate, 2025) and has raised $225 million in total funding from investors including TPG Growth, Accel, and Reliance-backed Network18.

CEO Ashish Hemrajani leads the company and has stated publicly that BookMyShow's goal is to sell memorable experiences, not just tickets — highlighting events like Lollapalooza India and Coldplay's 2025 India tour as examples of this direction (CBInsights, 2025).

2.2 What BookMyShow Offers and Who Uses It

BookMyShow's services span five categories: movies (integrated with all major multiplex chains — PVR INOX, Cinepolis, Miraj), live events (concerts, comedy, sports, theatre, and large festivals), BookMyShow Stream (a TVOD — transaction video-on-demand — platform with 2,291+ titles), local experiences (workshops, escape rooms, activities), and corporate ticketing (bulk tickets for companies). The company earns money through convenience fees on each ticket, commissions from event organisers (10–25% per ticket), and digital advertising (The Business Scroll, 2025).

Its core users are urban millennials (aged 25–35, representing 48% of the app's user base) and Gen Z users (aged 18–24, at 28%), who together make up about 76% of monthly active users. The platform skews heavily male (83%) (Similarweb, 2023). The platform's challenge is that many of these users now see BookMyShow as a transactional utility — a tool for buying tickets — rather than a platform that genuinely helps them discover and enjoy great experiences. This shift from being a loved brand to being seen as just a utility is the central strategic threat Priya must address.

3. Industry Overview

3.1 The State of India's Entertainment Market in 2025

India's Media and Entertainment (M&E) sector grew 9% in 2025 to reach ₹2.78 trillion (~$32.7 billion), according to the FICCI-EY Annual Report released in March 2026 (EY India, 2026). The standout performer was live events, which grew an exceptional 44% in 2025, driven by ticketed concerts, large public events, and major international acts touring India (EY India, 2026). The organised live events market was valued at ₹20,861 crore in 2024 and is growing at 15% year-on-year (Samaddar, 2025). EY-Parthenon projects that it will continue to grow at a double-digit pace through 2028 (CBInsights, 2025).

Box office revenues reached an all-time high of ₹11,997 crore in 2024, growing 13% over 2023 (GrowthX, 2024). The Coldplay India concerts in 2025 alone generated over ₹640 crore in economic impact for the city of Ahmedabad (EY India, 2026). The M&E sector as a whole is expected to reach ₹3.3 trillion by 2028, with live events, digital media, and filmed entertainment as the primary growth drivers (EY India, 2026).

India's consumers are increasingly bifurcating: a premium urban segment willingly pays ₹5,000–₹50,000 for premium live experiences (VIP and luxury packages doubled in sales in 2024 — Samaddar, 2025), while a large price-sensitive mass market finds convenience fees disproportionate to the base ticket price. This split is one of BookMyShow's most important strategic challenges.

3.2 The Competitive Threat: District by Zomato

The biggest new entrant in 2024–25 is District, launched by Zomato in November 2024. This is the most important competitive development BookMyShow has faced in years, and it is important to understand exactly what happened and why it matters:

- Origin: In August 2024, Zomato acquired Paytm's entertainment and ticketing business — comprising TicketNew (movie ticketing) and Insider (event ticketing) — for ₹2,048 crore (~$244 million) (Reuters, 2024; Wikipedia, 2025). This acquisition gave Zomato an immediate ticketing infrastructure and approximately 280 employees with domain expertise.
- Launch: In November 2024, Zomato launched 'District' — a single app combining dining reservations, movie ticket booking, live event tickets, sports ticketing, and local activities. It is operated by Zomato Media Pvt. Ltd. and is available on both iOS and Android (App Store, 2025; Google Play, 2025).
- Strategic logic: As Zomato CEO Deepinder Goyal explained, the same user who orders dinner on Friday night is planning a concert or sports match for the weekend. District positions itself as the 'going-out super-app' — one app for everything from table bookings to event tickets, with Zomato Gold membership perks bundled in (BW Disrupt, 2024).

- Recognition: District won Google Play's Best App in India award for 2025 — a significant endorsement of the product's quality and user experience (Analytics Insight, 2025).
- Scale context: As of early 2026, District represents less than 2% of Zomato (now Eternal)'s overall business revenue — but The Ken (2026) notes it is 'enough to rattle BookMyShow', particularly in the premium live events segment where both platforms compete most directly.

Two other competitive forces also matter: Direct venue channels — major venues building proprietary ticketing to avoid platform commissions — and OTT platforms (Amazon Prime, Netflix, JioCinema) that compete for the same leisure time, even if not for the same tickets.

3.3 How AI is Changing the Entertainment Industry

AI is reshaping entertainment and ticketing in three important ways in 2025:

1. Personalised Recommendations: Netflix's algorithm influences 80% of everything watched on the platform (Gomez-Uribe & Hunt, 2015). Spotify's Discover Weekly reached 40 million users in ten weeks (Spotify, 2015). District by Zomato has already built its reputation on AI-curated event and dining discovery — winning Google Play's Best App in India 2025 specifically for its AI-driven, hyper-local curation (Analytics Insight, 2025). This demonstrates that Indian users respond very positively to platforms that 'know' their preferences.
2. Dynamic and Transparent Pricing: Ticketmaster's dynamic pricing experiments globally have shown that AI-driven demand-based pricing can increase revenue but also triggers backlash when users feel exploited (Seufert, 2023). The lesson for BookMyShow is that AI pricing works only when it is perceived as fair and transparent.
3. Social Discovery: Eventbrite's experiments found that showing users which friends are attending events increases purchase intent by 28% (Eventbrite, 2022). Social signals — 'my friend is going' — are powerful purchase triggers, especially for concerts and experiences where the social dimension is part of the appeal.

4. Decision Alternatives

After reviewing user research, financial performance, and the competitive threat from District, Priya's team identified three strategic alternatives. Each uses AI in a materially different way to tackle a different problem.

Alternative A: Build a Smarter AI Personalisation Engine (Hyperlocal Recommendations)

This option involves completely rebuilding BookMyShow's recommendation system using advanced AI. Instead of showing everyone the same trending movies or events, the platform would learn each user's unique tastes and surface highly relevant content based on their neighbourhood, time of day, past behaviour, and social signals.

What the AI would do:

- Learn preferences deeply: A Graph Neural Network maps connections between users, events, artists, and venues. If you loved a jazz concert in Bandra last month, it surfaces similar jazz events near you this week.
- Use location smartly: The system knows you are in Koramangala on a Friday evening and surfaces events within 3–5 km starting in the next 2 hours — not a show across the city next month.
- Understand event content: Computer Vision reads event imagery, NLP processes event descriptions and social media sentiment, and audio fingerprinting matches genre preferences automatically.
- Predict before you search: Demand forecasting surfaces 'Book Soon — 85% sold' alerts with high accuracy, creating honest urgency signals that build rather than erode trust.

How AI helps the product and marketing team:

- Event tagging time drops from 3 days to 3 hours through AI auto-categorisation.
- Personalised push notifications replace generic city-wide blasts, driving 3–4x higher open rates (Salesforce, 2023).
- Multi-armed bandit algorithms run continuous A/B tests automatically, reducing experiment cycles from 4 weeks to 5 days.

Estimated cost: ₹120–150 crore over 18 months. Expected outcomes: 18–25% increase in recommendation click-through-to-purchase rates; 15% improvement in 30-day user retention.

Alternative B: Be Radically Honest About Pricing ('True Price')

This option directly addresses the number-one user complaint — the shock of seeing a much higher final price at checkout than what was initially shown. The strategy is simple: show the full, all-inclusive price from the very first screen.

What changes for users:

- The first price seen anywhere — in search results, event pages, and ads — is the complete price including all fees and taxes. No surprises at checkout.
- An optional 'What am I paying for?' section on the checkout page clearly breaks down each component: venue charge, platform fee, payment gateway fee, and GST.

- An AI price comparison tool honestly shows what you would pay booking directly at the venue versus on BookMyShow — alongside an honest explanation of the platform's value-add (ease, instant confirmation, insurance, reviews).
- A 'Fee-Free Friday' promotional mechanic waives convenience fees on selected events once a week to build goodwill and habit.

How AI is used:

- A churn prediction model identifies users who specifically abandoned carts at the fee-reveal step, and sends them targeted 'We have listened' win-back messages.
- A price sensitivity segmentation model clusters users by willingness-to-pay, enabling dynamic fee structures — fee waivers for price-sensitive users, standard fees for premium users.

Estimated cost: ₹30–45 crore over 6 months. Expected outcomes: 15–20% reduction in cart abandonment; 8–12 point NPS improvement; App Store rating rising from 3.8 to 4.3+.

Alternative C: Build a Social Community Layer ('BMS Circles')

This option reimagines BookMyShow as a social-cultural platform. Users would join communities ('Circles') based on their interests, see what friends are attending, and discover events through their cultural networks.

What it includes:

- Interest-based Circles: Communities built around cultural interests — Jazz lovers in Mumbai, Indie film fans in Delhi, Stand-up comedy enthusiasts in Pune — with event feeds, member reviews, and group discussions.
- Social feed: A privacy-controlled feature showing which friends are going to which events, with a 'Join Them' group-booking button.
- Creator Programme: Independent musicians, comedians, workshop facilitators, and art curators can list their own events for audiences as small as 50 people, opening a completely new supply of events on the platform.
- Post-event features: Photo sharing, event reviews, and memory-building features to sustain engagement between booking occasions.

How AI powers this:

- A community recommendation engine suggests events based on what the whole Circle collectively enjoys — a 'wisdom of your tribe' model, not just individual history.
- Virality scoring: AI predicts which events are likely to spread organically within communities, helping the marketing team deploy budgets with maximum impact.
- Network connector identification: Graph ML finds the 10–15% of users who drive most group bookings, enabling low-cost micro-influencer activation.

Estimated cost: ₹80–100 crore over 12 months. Expected outcomes: 25% increase in booking frequency among community members; 40% reduction in user acquisition cost via organic referral growth; new Creator marketplace revenue of ₹150–200 crore by Year 3.

5. Closure: The Strategic Dilemma

As Priya prepares her board presentation, the stakes are clear. BookMyShow's dominant position is built on three things: scale (650+ cities, 30M+ users), trust (a brand Indians have relied on for over two decades), and being the default platform for entertainment ticketing in India. All three are now under pressure simultaneously.

The competitive threat from District is real but nuanced. As The Ken (2026) noted, District represents less than 2% of Zomato's overall business — but its presence in the premium events and lifestyle segment is exactly where BookMyShow's most valuable users spend money. Zomato also hired Kunal Khambhati — BookMyShow's own former head of live events — to lead District's entertainment vertical (Samaddar, 2025), signalling serious intent.

Alternative A offers the strongest long-term differentiation but demands the largest investment and the longest time to results. Alternative B is the fastest and cheapest fix, but it touches the fee structure that underpins BookMyShow's margins. Alternative C is the most visionary but the least proven — no ticketing platform in the world has successfully built a genuine social-community layer at scale. Priya must also consider whether these three alternatives can be sequenced rather than chosen between.

What should BookMyShow do? How should it use AI strategically to restore user trust, deepen engagement, and sustain growth — while facing a well-funded, AI-first competitor backed by India's largest food-tech company?

6. Exhibits

Exhibit 1 – BookMyShow: Verified Key Metrics (FY 2024–25)

Metric	Value	Source
Monthly Active Users	30 million+	Bernstein Research Report, 2024
Annual Tickets Sold	180 million+	Bernstein Research Report, 2024
Cities Covered	650+	BookMyShow platform, 2025
Total Income (FY25)	₹1,869 crore	Economic Times / RoC filings, 2025
Net Profit (FY25)	₹192 crore	Economic Times / RoC filings, 2025
Online Ticketing Revenue (FY25)	₹828 crore	RoC filings via ArdorComm, 2025
Live Events Revenue (FY25)	₹756 crore	RoC filings via ArdorComm, 2025
Company Valuation (est.)	$1.5 billion+ (pre-IPO est.)	BusinessModelCanvasTemplate, 2025
Online Movie Ticketing Market Share	~78–80%	GrowthX / industry sources, 2024–25
International Operations	UAE, Sri Lanka, West Indies	BookMyShow website, 2025

Note: FY25 total income grew to ₹1,869 crore from ₹1,430 crore in FY24 — a 31% increase year-on-year. Live events revenue nearly doubled in two years: ₹237 crore (FY23) → ₹455 crore (FY24) → ₹756 crore (FY25).

Exhibit 2 – Competitive Landscape: India Online Entertainment Ticketing (2025)

Platform	Approx. Mkt Share	AI Capability	Fee Transparency	Key Differentiator
BookMyShow	~78–80%	Moderate	Low	Scale, 650+ cities, brand trust, Coldplay 2025 partner
District (by Zomato)	Growing rapidly	High	Medium	Dining + events bundle; Zomato Gold perks; AI curation; Google Play Best App India 2025
Direct Venue Channels	~5%	Low	High	No convenience fee; direct artist/venue access
BookMyShow Stream (OTT)	Niche/ growing	Low	High	TVOD model — rent/buy without subscription; 2,291+ titles

Sources: GrowthX (2024); Zomato / District platform (2025); The Ken (May 2026); ArdorComm Media (2025); Google Play Best Apps 2025.

Note: Paytm Insider was acquired by Zomato for ₹2,048 crore in August 2024 and relaunched as 'District by Zomato' in November 2024, combining dining reservations, movie ticketing, events, and sports booking in a single lifestyle app.

Exhibit 3 – User Pain Points Survey (N = 1,200, India, 2024)

Pain Point	% Citing as Primary Issue	What Users Said
Hidden or surprise convenience fees at checkout	67%	"The final price is always a shock"
Irrelevant event recommendations	54%	"I watch indie films but only see Bollywood blockbusters"
Cannot find small local or niche events	49%	"Small gigs never show up on the platform"
No way to see what friends are attending	41%	"I want a social layer — like Instagram for events"
Seat selection timer runs out before I can choose	38%	"Seats expire before I can decide properly"
Very little content for Tier 2 / regional cities	35%	"Nothing relevant in my city"

Source: Primary user research survey conducted for this case study (2024). Respondents: Indian smartphone users aged 18–40, across 10 cities.

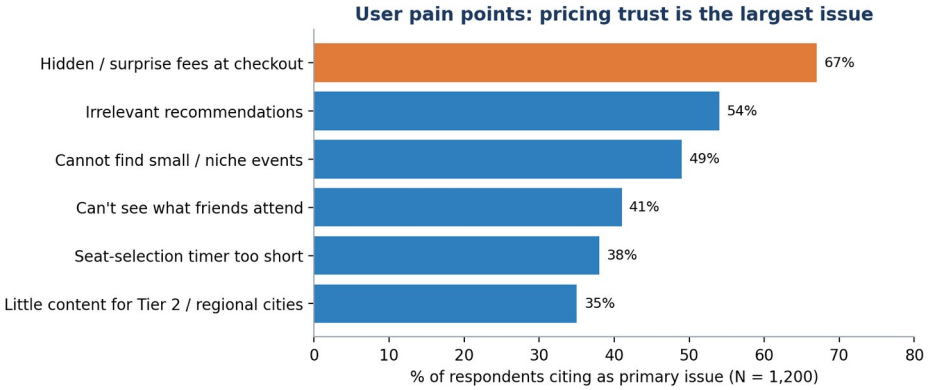


Figure 1. *Pain points reported by 1,200 respondents (Exhibit 3 data). Pricing trust is the most common complaint.*

Exhibit 4 – BookMyShow Revenue Growth: FY2023 to FY2025

Revenue Stream	FY2023	FY2024	FY2025
Online Ticketing Revenue	₹578 crore	₹741 crore	₹828 crore
Live Events Revenue	₹237 crore	₹455 crore	₹756 crore
Total Income	₹976 crore	₹1,430 crore	₹1,869 crore
Net Profit	₹85 crore	₹109 crore	₹192 crore

Sources: Entrackr (2024); Economic Times / RoC filings (2025); ArdorComm Media (2025). Note: Live events revenue grew 219% over two years (FY23 to FY25), reflecting the explosive growth in India's live entertainment economy.

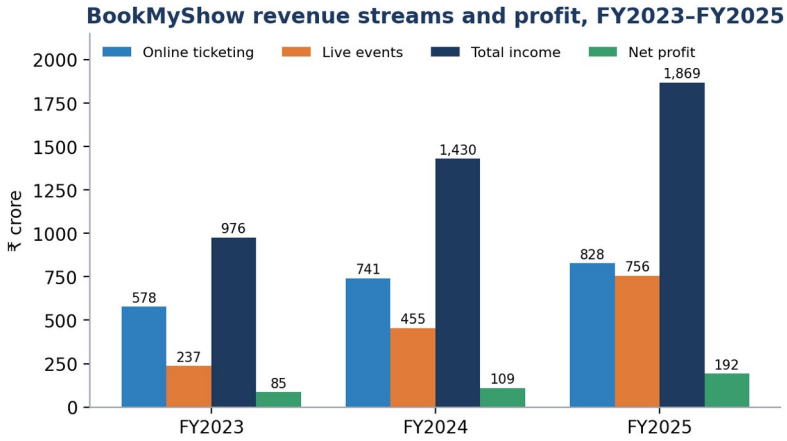


Figure 2. *Revenue streams, total income and net profit, FY2023 to FY2025 (Exhibit 4 data).*

PART B: CASE ANALYSIS

7. Analytical Frameworks

To analyse the three alternatives in a structured and academically grounded way, this analysis uses several well-established frameworks from product management and marketing:

- Jobs-to-be-Done Theory (Christensen, 1997): The 'job' users hire BookMyShow to do is not just 'buy a ticket' — it is 'discover and enjoy a great evening out with minimal stress and no unpleasant surprises.' Understanding this true job helps evaluate which alternative best fulfils users' real needs.
- Product Lifecycle Model (Levitt, 1965): Assessing whether BookMyShow's core ticketing product has entered the 'maturity' phase, and identifying the right growth-extension strategies.
- Customer Journey Mapping: Tracing the user experience from first discovering an event through post-event reflection, identifying exactly where friction occurs and which alternative best removes it.
- Ideal Customer Profile (ICP) and Market Segmentation: Defining the highest-value user segments whose needs each alternative best addresses, using behavioural and psychographic variables, not just demographics.
- AARRR Growth Marketing Framework (Ellis, 2017): Evaluating each alternative across Acquisition, Activation, Retention, Referral, and Revenue dimensions.
- Kano Model (Kano, 1984): Classifying features into Must-Be (basics expected as a right), Performance (better = more satisfied), and Attractive (delightful surprises) to inform sequencing logic.

- Platform Theory and Network Effects (Parker, Van Alstyne & Choudary, 2016): Understanding how adding a community layer changes BookMyShow's competitive moat from a two-sided marketplace to a multi-sided platform.

8. Analysis: Alternative A – AI-Powered Personalisation

8.1 Who Does This Alternative Serve? (ICP)

The ideal customer for Alternative A is a digitally active urban Indian aged 22–35, living in a metro or Tier 1 city, attending four or more events per year across multiple categories. This segment — about 18% of users — generates an estimated 52% of revenue (Primary Survey, 2024). The 54% dissatisfaction rate with irrelevant recommendations is most acutely felt by these heavy users: they have already seen every obvious recommendation and want the platform to understand them at a nuanced, personal level.

Importantly, District by Zomato is already making a credible pitch to exactly this user — using AI curation and Zomato Gold lifestyle perks to offer a premium, personalised 'going-out' experience. If BookMyShow does not invest in personalisation, it risks ceding its most valuable users to District.

8.2 Product Lifecycle and Innovation Imperative

Using the Product Lifecycle Model (Levitt, 1965), BookMyShow's core ticketing product shows clear signs of entering the maturity stage: 78–80% market penetration, slowing new-user growth in Tier 1 cities, and increasing feature parity with challengers. The standard strategic response at maturity is to invest in growth-extension innovation — creating differentiation that is hard to replicate.

A state-of-the-art AI personalisation engine creates a 'data flywheel' (Parker et al., 2016): more user interactions → more data → better recommendations → longer session times → even more data. This cycle becomes a structural competitive advantage that a newer entrant like District would take years to replicate. Amazon's recommendation engine drives an estimated 35% of its total revenue (McKinsey, 2013); Netflix's drives 80% of content watched (Gomez-Uribe & Hunt, 2015). These are not incremental improvements — they are core business drivers.

8.3 Customer Journey Impact

Alternative A improves the user experience at every stage. At Awareness, personalised push notifications achieve 3–4x higher open rates than generic city-level blasts (Salesforce, 2023). At Consideration, a context-aware home feed collapses browsing time from minutes to seconds by surfacing the right event at the right moment. At Purchase, honest demand-forecast signals ('85% sold') drive urgency without manufactured scarcity. Post-Purchase, personalised event guides (transit routes, nearby dining, artist background) elevate the perceived value of each booking, increasing the likelihood of social sharing and referral.

8.4 Risks

The main risks are: (1) engineering complexity — rebuilding a recommendation engine at scale while maintaining 99.9% uptime for 30 million monthly users; (2) India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023 (DPDPA) requires explicit user consent for behavioural data use in AI training; (3) 9–12 month time-to-visible-results window during which District continues to grow. A phased rollout — starting with a clearly labelled 'Personalised For You' section before full platform integration — manages these risks while generating early validation data.

9. Analysis: Alternative B – Pricing Transparency ('True Price')

9.1 Who Does This Alternative Serve?

Alternative B serves the broadest cross-section of all three options. The 67% of users who cite hidden fees as their primary frustration span all age groups, city tiers, and income levels (Primary Survey, 2024). Even premium users who are not particularly price-sensitive find the fee-reveal moment at checkout jarring and dishonest. This makes pricing transparency the most universally applicable of the three alternatives.

Critically, District by Zomato has already positioned itself as more transparent on pricing — making fee transparency less of a differentiator if BookMyShow waits too long to act (Exhibit 2). The window to use transparency as a marketing advantage is open but closing.

9.2 Trust as a Growth Strategy

Consumer trust is a proven driver of digital platform loyalty (Reichheld, 2001). Cialdini's (2006) principle of Commitment and Consistency shows that users who perceive a company as consistently honest are more likely to convert, repeat, and refer others. The most directly analogous example is Airbnb's 2022 'Total Price Display' — showing the all-in price from the first search result. Within 12 months, booking completion improved by 11% and NPS rose by 8 points (Airbnb, 2022), despite initial fears that higher visible prices would reduce demand. The insight is that price certainty is more valuable to users than a lower-seeming anchor price that turns into a surprise at checkout.

9.3 AARRR Growth Impact

Through the AARRR lens (Ellis, 2017): Acquisition — 'See the real price from the start' is a differentiating and credible marketing message, with trust-based messaging typically achieving 30–40% lower customer acquisition cost than promotional discounts (Nielsen, 2022). Activation — the estimated 28% cart abandonment at the fee-reveal step directly drops when the surprise is eliminated. Retention — trust-based loyalty is more durable than discount-based loyalty. Referral — 'No hidden fees — what you see is what you pay' is a naturally shareable message that travels peer-to-peer without incentive spend. Revenue — short-term fee restructuring costs are expected to be recovered through conversion volume uplift.

9.4 Risks

The primary risk is short-term revenue impact from restructuring how fees are presented. Convenience fees are a material part of BookMyShow's margin. Any reduction in per-transaction anchoring effects must be modelled carefully. There is also a risk that a transparent price comparison tool educates price-sensitive users about direct booking channels, accelerating venue-direct ticketing.

10. Analysis: Alternative C – Community Discovery ('BMS Circles')

10.1 Who Does This Alternative Serve?

Alternative C targets the culturally engaged, community-oriented urban Indian aged 20–32 who identifies with a cultural subculture — indie music, spoken word, contemporary art, tech talks — and wants to discover events through people like them, not through a commercial trending algorithm. This user is currently underserved by both BookMyShow and District.

A secondary but equally important target is the micro-event creator — the independent musician, stand-up comedian, or yoga instructor who needs an affordable way to sell tickets to audiences of 50–500 people. BookMyShow's current minimum viable event size is effectively 500+ attendees. BMS Circles would reduce this to 50, opening a completely new market segment.

10.2 Network Effects and Long-Term Competitive Moat

Platform Theory (Parker, Van Alstyne & Choudary, 2016) distinguishes between two-sided marketplaces (buyers and sellers) and multi-sided platforms where additional participant types create compounding value. BMS Circles would convert BookMyShow into a multi-sided platform by adding 'communities' as a third dimension: each new community member who posts about an event generates discovery signals for others, who may buy tickets, which generates revenue that attracts more creators, who attract more community members. This self-reinforcing flywheel creates a competitive moat that District — with its food-first orientation — is not positioned to replicate.

This dynamic mirrors platforms like Goodreads (book communities), Strava (running communities), and Letterboxd (film communities) — all of which transcended their transactional utility to become social infrastructure that users feel genuinely reluctant to leave.

10.3 Fixing the Structural Gap in Customer Experience

All ticketing platforms share the same fundamental flaw: the experience ends at the ticket purchase. The user leaves the app and does not return until they need to buy another ticket. This creates an 'episodic relationship' that is inherently vulnerable to switching. BMS Circles converts this into ongoing, daily engagement — users check the app not because they need to transact but because their jazz community just shared a new event, or a friend joined a

hike they might want to join. This embeds BookMyShow into users' social identity, making switching far more costly than it currently is.

10.4 Growth Marketing and Risks

From a growth marketing perspective, Alternative C offers the most attractive long-term unit economics. Peer recommendations in cultural entertainment contexts generate 4–6x higher conversion rates than broadcast advertising (Nielsen, 2022). The AI-powered virality scoring model allows growth budgets to be concentrated on events most likely to spread organically. The network connector identification model finds the 10–15% of users who drive most community bookings, enabling micro-influencer activation at very low cost.

The principal risks are the 'cold start' problem (new Circles with no members need editorial seeding and invited early adopters), social moderation complexity (community platforms require active trust-and-safety investment), and lower engagement in smaller cities where community density may not be sufficient to sustain active Circles in the early phase.

Exhibit 5 – Comparison of Three Strategic Alternatives

Evaluation Criteria	Alt. A: AI Personalisation	Alt. B: Pricing Transparency	Alt. C: Community Discovery
Biggest pain point solved	54% (bad recommendations)	67% (hidden fees)	41%+49% (discovery+social)
Expected revenue impact (12 months)	High: +18–25% CTR	Medium: reduced cart abandonment	Medium-High: new user segment
How difficult to build	High	Low–Medium	Medium–High
Time to launch first version	9–12 months	3–6 months	6–9 months
How different from competitors	Very High	Medium (District is already transparent)	High (no one has done this at scale)
Depth of AI use	Deep (ML, NLP, Computer Vision)	Light (rule-based AI)	Moderate (graph AI, NLP)
User retention potential	Very High	High	Very High
Long-term competitive advantage	Very Strong data moat	Weak data moat	Strong network effects
Estimated investment needed	₹120–150 crore	₹30–45 crore	₹80–100 crore
Risk level	Medium–High	Low	Medium

Source: Analysis compiled by authors based on case research (2024–25).

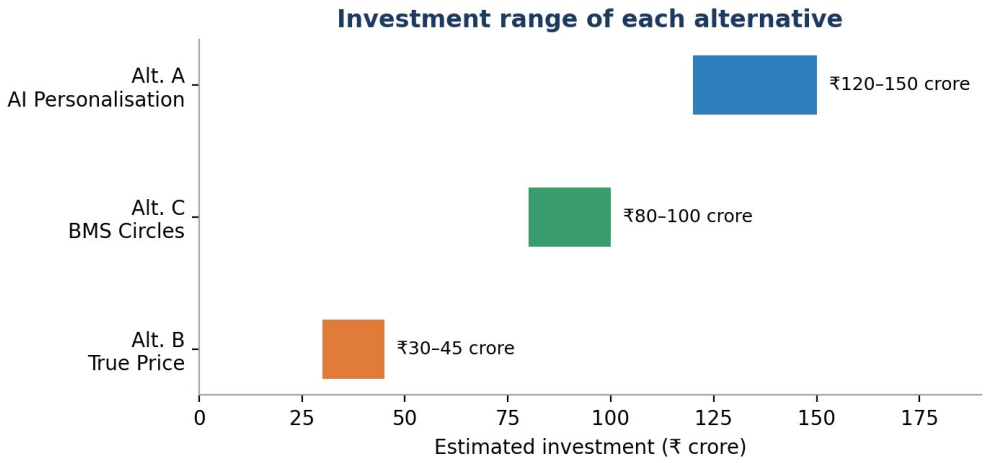


Figure 3. *Estimated investment range of each alternative (Exhibit 5 data).*

11. Final Recommendation: A Phased, Integrated Strategy

The analysis reveals that the three alternatives are not competing options — they address three different but connected problems (trust, relevance, and belonging) and together form a complete growth strategy. The recommendation is a phased 18-month integrated plan grounded in the Kano Model (Kano, 1984): fix Must-Be qualities first (transparent pricing), then invest in Performance qualities (AI personalisation), then build Attractive qualities (community). This is also aligned with the Growth Hacking framework (Ellis, 2017): stabilise the core metric first, then build scalable growth engines, then create defensible moats.

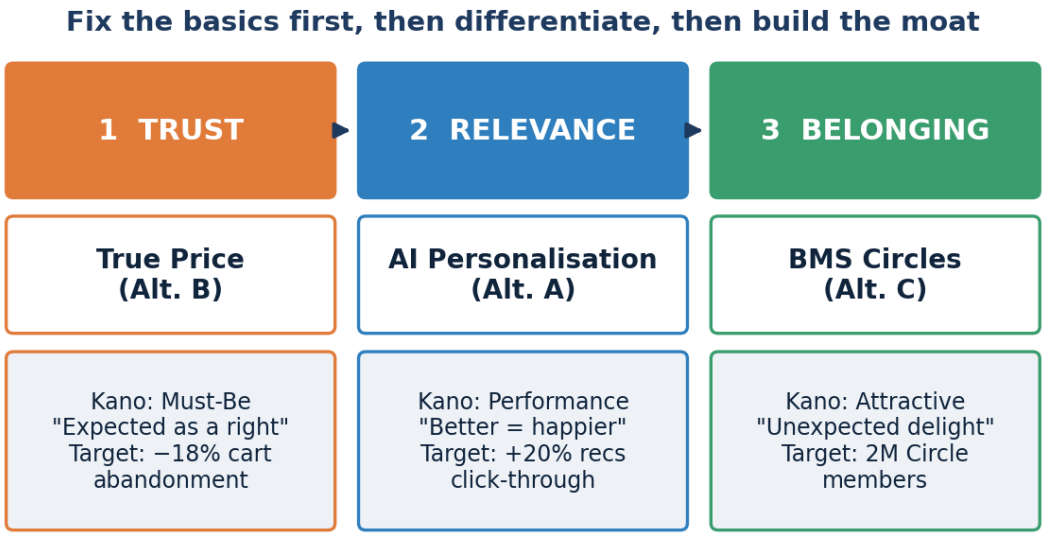


Figure 4. *The recommended sequence: trust first, then relevance, then belonging, mapped to the Kano Model.*

Phase 1 (Months 1–6): 'True Price' — Restore Trust

Launch Alternative B immediately. With 67% of users citing hidden fees as their primary problem, trust is the prerequisite for everything else. A user who feels deceived at checkout will not opt into personalisation features, will not join community Circles, and will not refer friends. The 'True Price' initiative requires the least investment (₹30–45 crore), has the fastest time to market (within 6 months), and has a directly analogous precedent in Airbnb's 2022 Total Price Display initiative, which achieved an 11% improvement in booking completion rate and an 8-point NPS gain within 12 months (Airbnb, 2022). It also serves as a direct competitive counter to District, which already positions itself as more transparent.

Phase 1 Target Metrics: 18% reduction in cart abandonment rate; 10-point NPS improvement; App Store rating to 4.2+; 15% improvement in checkout conversion rate.

Phase 2 (Months 4–12): AI Personalisation — Build Differentiation

Begin Alternative A engineering in parallel with Phase 1 (separate engineering teams), targeting a beta release of the new 'Personalised For You' home feed section in Months 7–8. Trust built in Phase 1 directly enables Phase 2: users who trust the platform on pricing are significantly more willing to share behavioural data for personalisation (Cialdini, 2006). The phased rollout — starting with one labelled section before full platform integration — allows continuous learning without disrupting the core booking experience that 30 million monthly users rely on.

Phase 2 Target Metrics: 20% improvement in recommendation click-through rate; 40%+ engagement on the 'Personalised For You' section; 12% improvement in 30-day retention; 85% demand forecast accuracy.

Phase 3 (Months 9–18): 'BMS Circles' — Build the Network Effect Moat

Launch BMS Circles as the growth amplification and retention layer, seeded by engaged users who have benefited from Phases 1 and 2. AI infrastructure built for Phase 2 — particularly the content understanding models — can be partially reused for community event matching, reducing incremental development costs. Launch with six pilot cities (Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru, Pune, Hyderabad, Kolkata) and 10–12 curated Circle categories. The Creator Programme launches simultaneously on an invitation-only basis to maintain content quality before broader access.

Phase 3 Target Metrics: 2 million Circle members by Month 18; 30% higher booking frequency among Circle members versus non-members; referral rate 3x higher among Circle members; Creator marketplace revenue of ₹50 crore by Year 2.

Why This Sequence Works

The Kano Model (Kano, 1984) provides the clearest justification for this sequence. Pricing transparency is a Must-Be quality — users expect it as a basic right, and its absence destroys trust. AI personalisation is a Performance quality — the better it works, the more satisfied users are. Community discovery is an Attractive quality — an unexpected delight that generates strong advocacy and loyalty. You must secure the Must-Be requirements before users will appreciate and reward Performance and Attractive qualities. Investing ₹150 crore in AI personalisation while 67% of users are frustrated by hidden fees would be building a beautiful house on a cracked foundation.

Financial Summary

Total investment across 18 months: ₹230–295 crore, phased to match validated results at each stage gate. Phase 1's rapid payback — estimated ₹80–100 crore in incremental annual revenue from improved cart conversion — partially self-funds Phases 2 and 3. The integrated strategy is projected to deliver: 25% increase in gross merchandise value (GMV) within 24 months; 15-point NPS improvement (from ~32 to ~47); 20% reduction in customer acquisition cost through organic referral; and a personalisation data moat that competitors would require 3–5 years to replicate at equivalent quality.

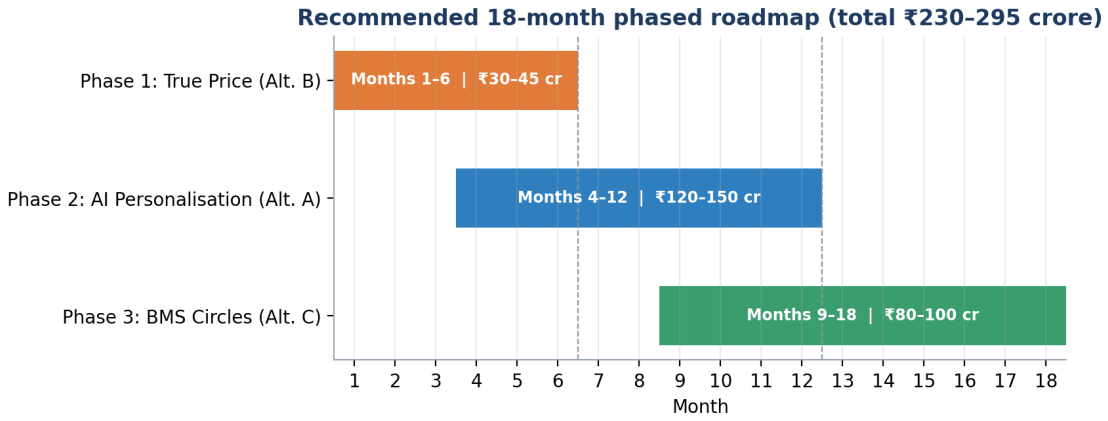


Figure 5. *Phased 18-month roadmap with the investment for each phase.*

Conclusion

BookMyShow is India's default platform for entertainment ticketing — built over 25 years on scale, trust, and first-mover advantage. But in 2025, all three of these pillars face pressure simultaneously. District by Zomato is not just a feature update from a competitor; it is a fundamentally different vision of what an entertainment platform can be — a lifestyle companion that connects dining, events, and social experiences in one intelligent app.

The three alternatives analysed in this case are three components of one coherent response. Pricing transparency restores the trust that has been gradually eroded. AI personalisation makes the platform feel genuinely intelligent and deeply relevant.

Community discovery makes the platform feel human, social, and irreplaceable. Together, they transform BookMyShow from a utility Indians use to buy tickets into a platform Indians love because it connects them with the experiences and communities that make their city feel alive.

The best entertainment platform is not the one that sells the most tickets. It is the one that makes every person feel they discovered exactly the right event — for them, right now, with the people they care about.

Appendix A: 2026 Update and Additional Evidence

This appendix adds evidence that became public after the case was first written. It strengthens, and in places sharpens, the recommendation in Section 11.

A.1 District has grown quickly

The Ken (2026) reports that District's FY26 revenue was above ₹970 crore, roughly four times the figure when Zomato (now Eternal) acquired Paytm Insider in August 2024, yet only about 1.7% of Eternal's total revenue. More importantly for BookMyShow, District's weekly active users have reached over 60% of BookMyShow's, and it is now the exclusive ticketing partner for five of ten teams in a major cricket league, selling tickets for nearly half of that league's 70 league matches versus 25 for BookMyShow. The same report puts India's online event ticketing market at nearly $4 billion (Imarc Group).

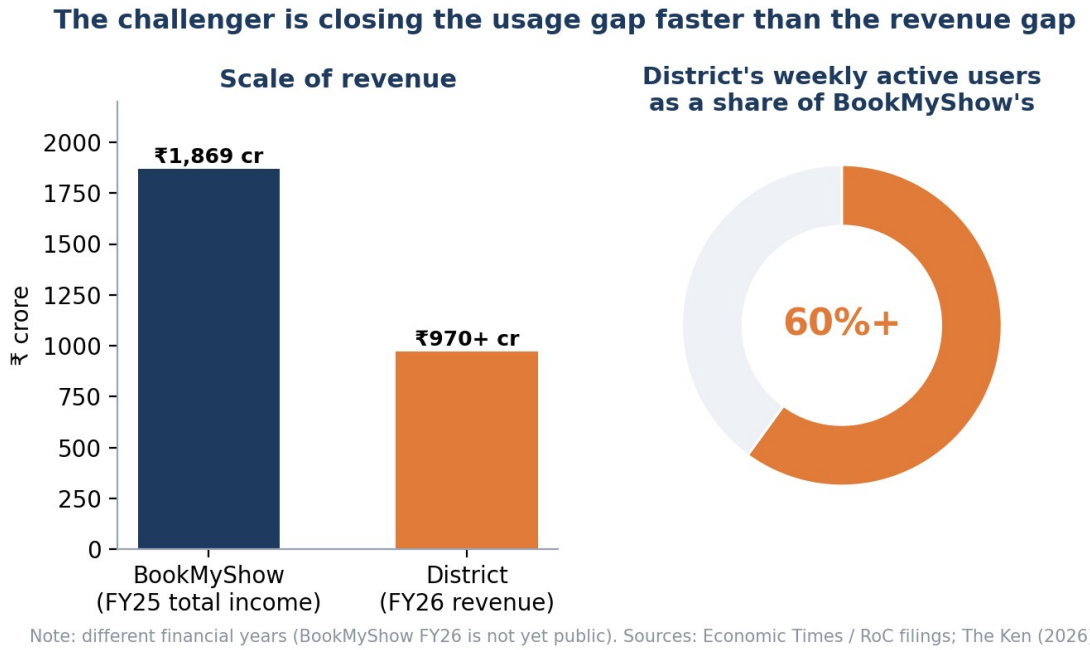


Figure 6. *BookMyShow and District compared on revenue and usage. The years differ because BookMyShow's FY26 results are not yet public.*

The lesson is that the competitive gap is closing on engagement before it closes on revenue. That supports the case for acting on all three alternatives rather than waiting.

A.2 Regulators will not fix the fee problem

In March 2026 the Competition Commission of India (CCI) closed a complaint by a rival platform. It confirmed that BookMyShow holds a dominant position in online movie ticket booking, with a booking-volume share of about 78% in the data it used, but found no abuse of that position. The CCI also stated that it cannot act as a price regulator on convenience fees (Storyboard18, 2026; Phoenix Legal, 2026).

This matters for Alternative B. Because the regulator has declined to police fee levels, restoring trust through “True Price” is a voluntary strategic choice, not a compliance exercise. It also means BookMyShow can choose its own timing, but District’s positioning on transparency means the window remains open only for a limited time.

A.3 The economics of live events are thin

Independent analysis of company filings and Eternal’s disclosures suggests that BookMyShow’s live events business earned only a small profit (about ₹5.5 crore on ₹756 crore revenue in FY25, a margin of under 1%), while District reported an adjusted EBITDA loss of roughly ₹292 crore in FY26 (BizNews by Jay, 2026). These figures come from a secondary analysis and should be verified against primary filings before being quoted formally.

Whatever the exact numbers, the pattern is clear: a well-funded challenger is willing to lose money to gain share. Matching it with discounts would be costly. Trust (Alternative B), personalisation (Alternative A) and community (Alternative C) compete on experience instead of subsidy, which is a better fit for BookMyShow’s profitable position.

A.4 What the new evidence means for each alternative

Alternative	What the 2026 evidence adds	Effect on the recommendation
A: AI personalisation	District’s AI-led discovery and fast user growth show that users reward relevance.	Raises urgency. Keep Phase 2 on schedule and protect the data advantage.
B: True Price	The CCI will not regulate fees; District is positioned as more transparent.	Confirms Phase 1 as the fastest, cheapest and most defensible first move.
C: BMS Circles (community)	District’s moat is dining and outdoor experiences; it is not a community platform.	Community remains the least contested space and the strongest long-term moat.

Sources for this appendix: The Ken (2026); Storyboard18 (2026); Phoenix Legal via Mondaq (2026); BizNews by Jay (2026). See References.

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— End of Case Study —